

Cyber Security Matters

Larry Clinton in a candid discussion about the cyber security landscape

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In an increasingly digital world, where the Internet is starting to define and control our very existence, threats to the system are wide-ranging and with debilitating effects. Larry Clinton, of Internet Security Alliance fame, knows all about them and authoritatively advocates cyber security norms to a wide-ranging audience that includes policy makers in the White House to university students halfway across the globe, and every stakeholder in between. Digit sat down with him to understand more about ISA, the cyber security landscape, and the need for collaborative and sustained cyber security policy to protect ourselves online. Excerpts from our interview:

■ Tell us a little bit about ISA and what they've done promoting cyber security?

The Internet Security Alliance is an international trade association started in 2000 it consists primarily of major multinational organizations who generally do a very good job with respect to cyber security – in that they're the industry leaders – but they're also interested in expanding the perimeter of cyber security, getting more organizations to promote cyber security, etc. So the ISA has three major goals. First is thought leadership. Cyber security is such a new era, that we really haven't figured out how to approach it, unlike a lot of other things, and thought leadership is very important. The second thing that we do is public policy advocacy. Because as I said, industry and government need to be working collectively to promote a sustainable system of cyber security. And the third is to promote the adoption of actual security practices and technology, so the mission of the ISA is to take advanced technology and blend it with economics to create a sustained system of cyber security. We see the problem very differently than most. Most

people have historically thought of cyber security primarily as a technical issue. We see it more as an economic issue. Actually, we know a great deal, technically, about how to solve our cyber security problems. But the incentives to promote good cyber security are not in place. So what we want to do is blend those economic incentives



Larry Clinton, President and CEO, Internet Security Alliance (ISA)

together with the advanced technology and have supportive government policy so that we create a sustained digital future for ourselves.

■ What according to you are the worst and more detrimental threats to cyber security that are out there on the Internet right now?

There are enormous numbers of threats out there. In fact you can go on the Internet and purchase them for very little money and make a lot of money with them. And the threats really run the gamut from fairly routine sorts of things that can be easily prevented all the way up to extremely sophisticated cyber techs. So the vast majority of cyber techs that are out there, maybe 80-95 per cent of those could

be properly dealt with simply by adopting standards and practices that are already existing in the community. For those it's really an implementation problem, not a development problem. And then there are the ultra-sophisticated attacks – things we call the advanced persistent threat or the APT. These are not hackers, these are ultra sophisticated individuals often affiliated with nation states who use increasingly sophisticated waves of cyber attack to constantly get in the system. So there's a whole range of things that we need to be aware of and different sorts of solutions that need to be put in place in order to deal with this growing problem.

■ What solutions? Do you have anything particular in mind from a technology perspective nation states, companies or even individuals can do on their own front to combat this threat?

Absolutely. As I mentioned, somewhere between 80-95% of cyberattacks could be easily prevented and frankly, fairly economically prevented simply by adopting well-known standards and practices that are already out in the market. The problem isn't that we don't know how to deal with cyber security. The problem is that we haven't been implementing the cyber security practices that we ought to be implementing.

Most of us, frankly, don't like security. Most of us, for example, if we buy a smartphone, we want something that's cheap and easy to use, or even pretty. Very few of us ask about the security features. And if there are security features on them, we tend to turn the security features off, because that slows things down. So people have to become aware of this, but we also have to motivate people much more to adopt the standards and practices that are out there.

■ You deal with policy makers day in, day out. Where do you rate their awareness